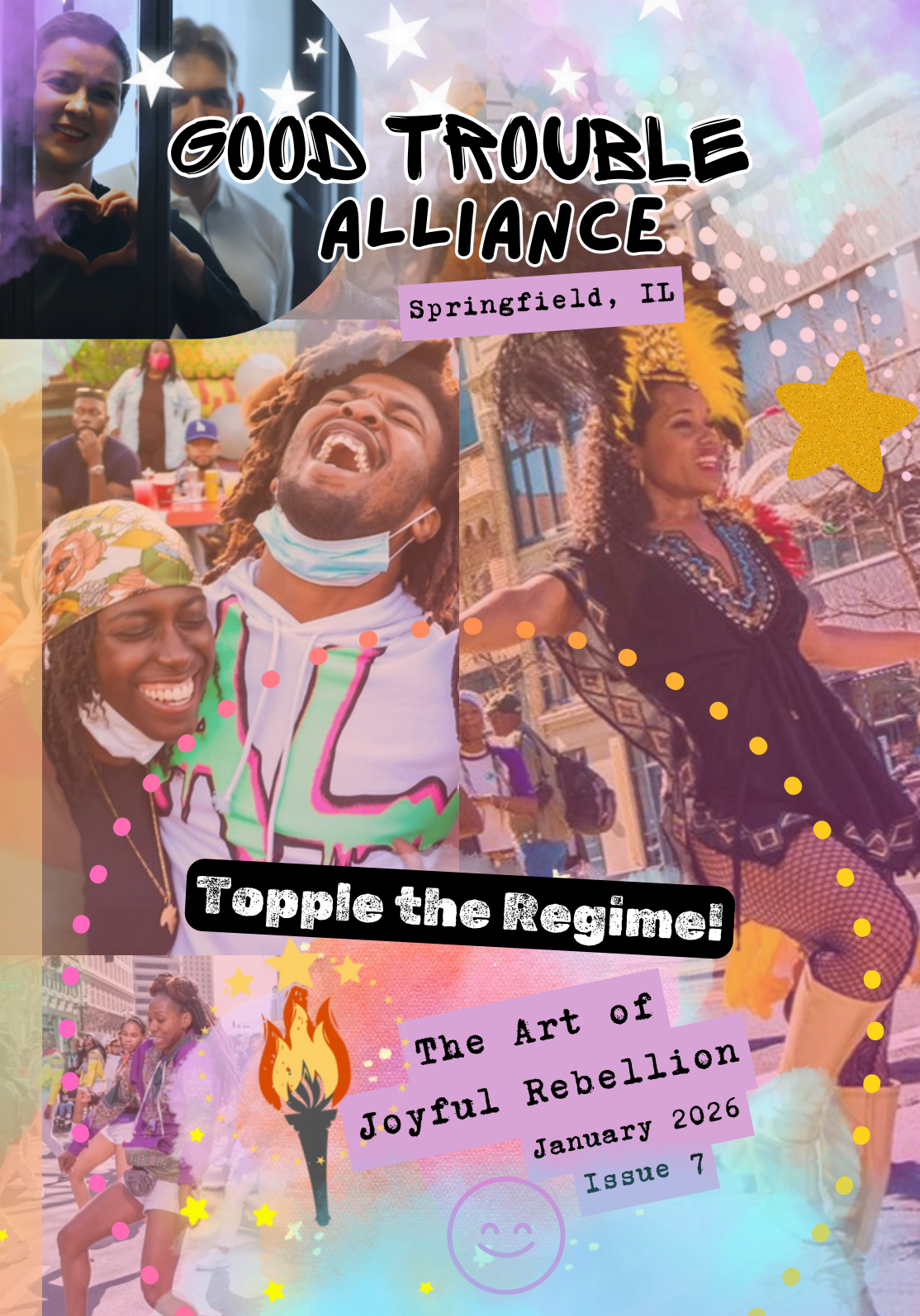




GOOD TROUBLE ALLIANCE

Springfield, IL

Topple the Regime!

The Art of
Joyful Rebellion
January 2026
Issue 7



**Against the assault of
laughter, nothing can stand.**

— Mark Twain



JOY IS REVOLUTIONARY!

"In many authoritarian regimes, there are forms of joy that are restricted or banned. Oppressors know **joy can be a dangerous force indeed!**"



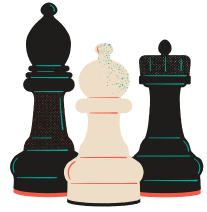
"...**Joy is an affirmation of life and a marker of our humanity**; denying it dehumanizes us. For centuries, people facing oppression have used music, dance, humour, art, and food to **experience joy amidst the most grueling of circumstances.**"

--beautifultrouble.org



HOW IS JOY STRATEGIC?

- ☀ Wins hearts
- ☀ Attracts followers
- ☀ Softens opposition
- ☀ Overcomes fear
- ☀ Demonstrates courage
- ☀ Creates hope
- ☀ Humanizes the movement
- ☀ Makes messages memorable



Joyful Tactics



- Song & Dance
- Street Art
- Flash Mobs
- Costumes
- Parties
- Pranks
- Jokes/Laughtivism
- Serving/Uplifting Others in Solidarity



In San Francisco, “Don’t Mess With Me” (2013/2020), aka *The Pink Lady* by Jas Charanjiva features a woman wearing brass knuckles that spell the word “Boom” in reference to a boom of awareness about women’s safety.

TEETER TOTTER ACTIVISM



“Women and children completely disempowered this wall for a moment, for 40 minutes”



Learn More



news.berkeley.edu

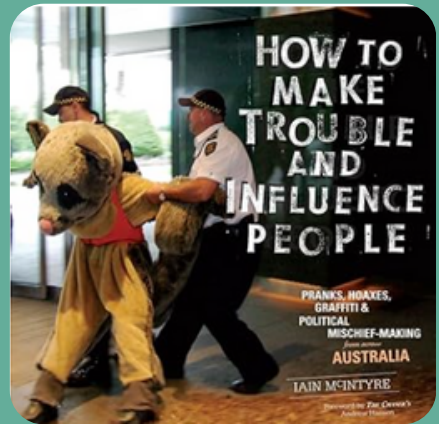


In 2019, UC Berkeley architect Ronald Rael created teeter totters that brought people together in play across the US/Mexico border wall. This was not just fun, but a poignant statement about a structure meant to divide.

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS

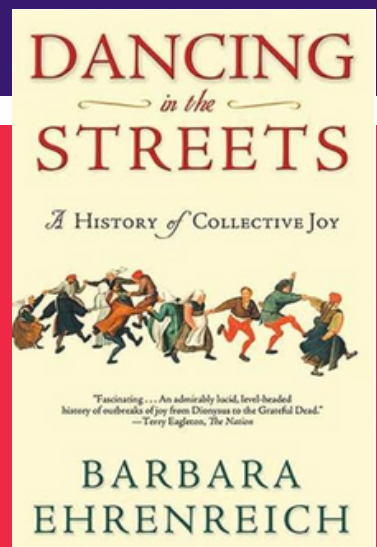
Are you in the mood
for...

Indigenous Australian
Troublemaking



Collection of
Black Resistance Essays

How Joy and Celebration
Challenged Authority
Throughout History



JANUARY GOOD TROUBLE STORIES

By Sarah Kate



JOYFUL TROUBLE THROUGHOUT HISTORY

**JOY, BEAUTY, AND
SOLIDARITY ARE AT
THE HEART OF THESE
GOOD TROUBLE
STORIES.**



HELEN TODD'S GOOD TROUBLE STORY

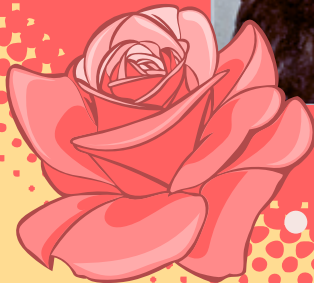
While we all must fight for bread
- our right to survive -

WE MUST ALSO NEVER LOSE
SIGHT OF OUR COLLECTIVE
RIGHT TO ROSES.

Suffragist and labor organizer
Helen Todd led the landmark
1912 “**Bread and Roses
Strike**” emphasizing that
**roses represent our right to
beauty, dignity, joy, and self-
enrichment.**



Helen Todd
(1870-1953)





Lawrence, MA

In Lawrence Massachusetts, Todd led thousands of women to defend their “right to roses”. **Pay cuts, hazardous working conditions, and crushing poverty, stoked their drive to strike.**



“Bread and Roses Strike” 1912



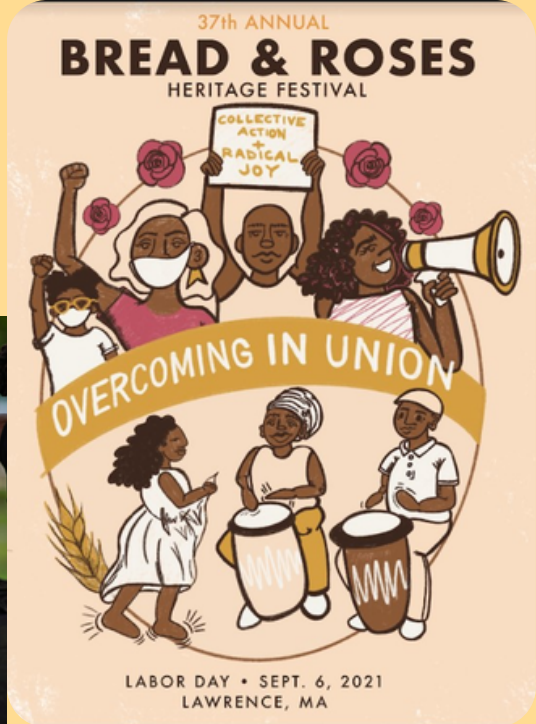


These women, primarily immigrant textile workers, **represented over 25 different nationalities** hailing from all over the world – from the Middle East, to various European nationalities, to French Canadians.



A few strike organizers **doubted that organizing workers across ethnic and linguistic lines was even possible.** Yet they came together and walked out for two months. **Ultimately, they proved naysayers wrong winning concessions from mill managers.**

***The Bread and Roses
Strike is still celebrated in
Lawrence, MA each year***



THE CHARLESTON CIGAR FACTORY

WOMEN'S GOOD TROUBLE STORY



In the early 1900s, **The Charleston Cigar Factory was a hub of industry** in Charleston, South Carolina. Hundreds of workers rolled cigars by hand in crowded, noisy rooms.



Though these workers were mostly women, they were **segregated by race and gender**. Women of all races were **underpaid with no chance for advancement** while white men were well paid and able to ascend to leadership.

The white factory managers raked in profits in the wake of World War II, but workers were suffering.

PREPARING TO STRIKE

In October of 1945, **a group of Black women at the factory prepared to strike for better working conditions**. The factory employed 1,400 people, at the time. 1,200 of them walked out. 900 of the protesters were Black women.

The strike's organizers demanded a \$0.65 cent minimum wage, an hourly pay raise of \$0.25, the right to a union shop, and an end to discrimination against Black workers.



WE SHALL OVERCOME



To keep spirits high as the winter grew colder, **at the end of each day of picketing, strikers sang the gospel song "I'll Overcome Someday."**



This song was subsequently revised into "We Shall Overcome," the famous anthem at the heart of the 1960s civil rights movement.

Strikers at the Charleston Cigar Factory **created a new and influential precedent for collaboration and power-building between labor and civil rights activists,** leading to a concerted effort by the CIO to make organizing inroads across the South.



MARTHA HOLMES' GOOD TROUBLE STORY



Laughter spills across the frame. Billy Eckstine leans forward, smiling broadly, as a woman presses against his chest, laughing with him. It's 1949, and *LIFE Magazine* photographer Martha Holmes has captured a **moment that many Americans did not want to see.**

Eckstine, one of the most popular singers of his time, was a biracial performer navigating the rigid lines of Jim Crow segregation. **Holmes' photograph shows something radical in its simplicity: joy shared across racial lines.** A Black man and white fans, laughing together, unguarded and human

The reaction was swift and ugly. ***LIFE Magazine* received furious letters calling the image "indecent"** and demanding it never be published again.

But Holmes never wavered. Reflecting on the photograph years later, she said,
"That picture was my favorite, because it told just what the world should be like."

PITS AND PERVERTS' GOOD TROUBLE STORY



The Electric Ballroom in Camden was packed, the music pulsing, lights flashing, and queer Londoners dancing with a purpose. It was December 10, 1984 — and this wasn't just a party. **It was the “Pits and Perverts”**

benefit ball, wryly named after a derogatory newspaper headline. The ball was not just a party, but a **fundraiser for striking Welsh coal miners, organized by Lesbians and Gays Support the Miners (LGSM).**

Headlined by the all-gay synth-pop band Bronski Beat, **the event drew 1,500 people and raised £20,000**, blending celebration and activism in a way no one had seen before. A miners' spokesperson told the crowd:

“Now 140,000 miners know that there are other causes and other problems. We know about Blacks and gays and nuclear disarmament, and will never be the same.”



That night, **the dancefloor became a stage for solidarity**, showing that resistance could be joyous, collective, and unapologetically queer.

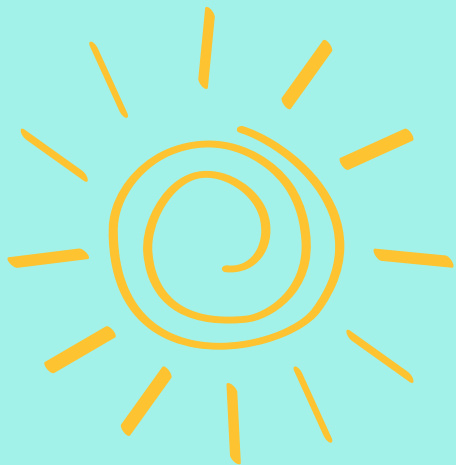
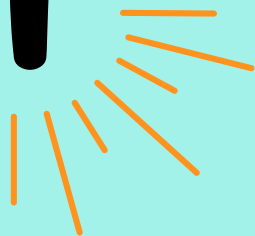
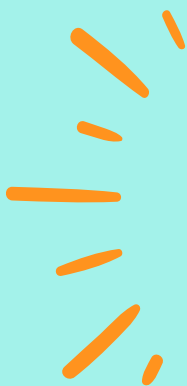


Reflection...

**How Can We Make
Our Activism**

Joyful

?



GOOD TROUBLE ALLIANCE INITIATIVES



HEALTHCARE ADVOCACY

Advocate voting to protect Healthcare in the 2026 midterm elections.

PROJECT DONUT

Help activists and police form healthier relationships by fostering dialogue, reducing conflict, and making protests safer.



CHALK LOVE

Spread hope, love and support for immigrants by chalking up Springfield sidewalks with love! 2nd Friday of every month at 6pm.

NEXT MEETING

Saturday, January 24

12pm

Multipurpose Room

Lincoln Library



Vision of Tomorrow

The Good Trouble Alliance wants the US to be **promoted from a “flawed democracy” to a “full democracy”** as per the standards established by the EIU’s annual report card on Democracy, including high scores in the following areas:



- Electoral Process and Pluralism
- Functioning of government
- Political Participation
- Political Culture
- Civil Liberties

We strive to live up to the ideals of civil resistance as we **strategically fight authoritarianism and human rights abuses in America**. We aim to be the spark that ignites a revolution of freedom and human decency.

For more information contact goodtrouble.springfield@gmail.com

